



research. Our aspiration is not simply to manufacture more products, but to manufacture smarter, create more value within the state, and generate high-quality jobs that will define the economy of the future.



How important is technical education in supporting manufacturing growth?

Manufacturing competitiveness ultimately depends on people. Tamil Nadu produces nearly 143,000 engineering graduates every year, supported by one of the highest gross enrolment ratios in higher education in the country. We are home to some of India's finest institutions, including IIT Madras and several of the country's highest-ranked engineering colleges. Equally important are the hundreds of engineering colleges, polytechnics and skill development institutions spread across the state, which create a deep and geographically diverse talent pipeline for industry.

However, today's industries require far more than academic qualifications. They need graduates who are industry-ready from Day One.

That is why our skilling initiatives increasingly involve industry participation in curriculum design, practical training, apprenticeships and certification. Over the last few years, more than 4.1 million young people have been trained through industry-aligned programmes developed in partnership with over 1,400 companies.

Another unique strength is the diversity of our workforce. Nearly 43% of India's women employed in manufacturing work in Tamil Nadu, making our industrial ecosystem one of the most inclusive in the country.

As manufacturing becomes more technology-driven, the demand for engineers, designers, AI specialists, data analysts and advanced technicians will only increase. For us, education, skilling and industrial policy are not separate agendas—they are different parts of the same strategy to build a globally competitive, innovation-led manufacturing economy.



Your government has recently concluded its maiden investment conclave, Vettri Tamil Nadu. With this, total investments under the government are over Rs 1 lakh crore. You have spoken about Tamil Nadu's next phase being about creating value rather than simply adding manufacturing capacity. Is the investment conclave an indication of this?

The conclave is a reflection of how Tamil Nadu's industrial ambition is evolving. The scale of investment is important, but more significant is the nature of the investments. We are increasingly seeing interest in areas such as advanced manufacturing, electronics, technology, engineering, clean energy and other sectors that have the potential to create greater value.

Fifteen industry sectors were represented, from data centres and auto to life sciences, aerospace and deep tech. This is exactly the diversification we have been speaking about earlier.



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Plus, we have around 25,500 projected jobs from the recent announcements. This is across sectors like electronics and semiconductors, aerospace and defence, life sciences, data centres and R&D and GCCs.



The state has attracted a significant pipeline of investments. How will you ensure that these MoUs translate into actual projects on the ground?

Investment announcements matter only when they translate into projects, jobs and economic value. Our focus therefore does not end with signing an MoU. The real work begins after that.

We are strengthening the mechanisms for project facilitation, approvals, land, infrastructure and coordination across departments, to ensure companies can quickly move from commitment to implementation.

Our approach is increasingly about conversion and execution. **BT**

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